FROM THE

EDITOR-IN-CHIEF

We entered 2022 with a sense of déjà vu because the new year seems a lot like the year gone by. Covid-19 cases are rising again and a far more contagious strain of the novel coronavirus is spreading across the globe. The good thing, though, is that two years on, Covid-19 is no longer an unknown unknown. We know the nature of the beast and experienced the worst of it last year when the Delta variant tore across India, triggering the second wave of infections, aggravated by an acute medical oxygen crisis and black fungus cases, all of which collectively killed over 200,000 people in the country. We are now far better prepared with vaccine stocks and the government's booster dose programme. Covid-19 has claimed 5.4 million lives globally, just a tenth of the estimated 50 million deaths from the 1918 influenza pandemic, also referred to as the 'Spanish flu'. The outbreak raged for about two years and infected a third of humanity.

The new Omicron strain of Covid, from all available evidence, is milder than Delta. That's a relief. Although we are still in the midst of the pandemic, we seem to be much better off. But this should not breed complacency. Viruses seldom behave the way you want them to. The world today has four times the population it had a century ago and is far more interconnected. One study finds that the global economy could lose almost $3 trillion (Rs 223 lakh crore) due to Covid-19. It is projected to grow at 4.3 per cent in 2022, slightly below the 5.8 per cent it achieved last year (after -3.3 per cent in 2020). The International Monetary Fund (IMF) estimates global GDP losses could rise to $5.3 trillion (Rs 393 lakh crore) over five years with several million lives lost. Strong economic growth is a key imperative for India if it is to pull more people out of poverty.



January 11, 2021



January 18, 2021

The pandemic's trajectory, particularly its linkage with the wellness of people, will be the most important factor determining global economic recovery in 2022. In addition to these two intertwined concerns, India has a third sharp end of a threat triangle to deal with—China. In May 2020, a belligerent Beijing shredded three decades of peace and tranquillity protocols when it moved heavy military units to the boundary in eastern Ladakh, where both sides remain entrenched.

Apart from concerns of health, economy and security, several other factors will weigh on the minds of the political establishment in 2022. This year, we celebrate the 75th anniversary of our independence. There will be elections to the office of the President and Vice-President and to seven state assemblies. The BJP is in power in six of these states, including Prime Minister Modi's home state of Gujarat. The party's strategy to fight anti-incumbency will be closely watched.

There are, however, more long-term concerns in the year ahead and beyond. Our special issue, '2022: Hope & Fear', put together by Editor (Features) Kai Friese, looks at these concerns through insights from a panel of experts in their particular fields. For instance, virologist Gangandeep Kang says science and public health, supported by policy, need to be at the forefront of our control endeavours because the threat from global waves of SARS-CoV-2 variants is not going away. China watcher Andrew Small explains that Beijing now has a greater appetite for escalating crises than it did in the past and thinks it can live with antagonistic relationships on multiple fronts. Former foreign secretary Shyam Saran believes 2022 will be more unpredictable and hopes for it to be India's year of a revitalised Act East policy and engagement with economic blocs, such as the Regional Comprehensive Economic Partnership (RCEP) and Asia-Pacific Economic Cooperation (APEC). Financial strategist Neelkanth Mishra feels India should seize the opportunity and focus on increasing its share of global trade, both in services and merchandise.

Economist Jahangir Aziz outlines five broad trends to watch for—Covid-19 turning endemic, the impact of COP26 commitments on future energy sources, a policy regime change in China, the permanent damage caused by the Covid pandemic, and global electoral cycles in the next few years. Environmentalist Sunita Narain says it is time for India to reinvent growth without pollution by designing a more resource efficient, affordable and sustainable climate change model. Former agriculture secretary Siraj Hussain and researcher Shweta Saini write about how the farmers' agitation against the central farm laws should not be seen as the end of the road for agricultural reforms. For technologist Rohan Murty, a major theme of 2022 will be deploying tech to improve people's experience at work.

The RSS, the BJP's ideological parent, will celebrate 100 years of its existence in 2025. According to RSS ideologue Ram Madhav, the challenge for the organisation will be to find a balance between pride and anger, ensuring that neither spills over. Author and Trinamool Congress leader Pavan K. Varma, however, argues that Hindutva aims to overturn the inclusiveness and eclecticism of Hinduism. Group Editorial Director (Publishing) Raj Chengappa writes about the need for the Modi government to stay the course on economic reforms. Senior advocate Arvind P. Datar says India must nurture the institutional independence of courts and tribunals if it wants to be treated on par with the great western democracies while globalisation specialist Parag Khanna sees the waves of migrating Indians as reshaping the world. Finally, sports writer Sharda Ugra predicts that the new year will be one of a resurgence of Indian athletes across all sport.

This is truly a galaxy of fine writers and if you want to know the direction the country and the world are taking, or ought to be taking, this special issue is a must read. Enjoy. ■

(Aroon Purie)